

Speaking Up

Vocabulary & Grammar Handout

Intermediate Level

CORRECTED VERSION

The following version corrects grammar and spelling errors from the original essay. Corrections are shown in bold.

On a beautiful Sunday morning, the warm sunlight sprinkled into my room silently. “How **a** comfortable **enjoyment!**” I whispered to myself as usual, but with no smile this time; the project **that was** assigned by Ms. Jacky **had** ruined **my** weekends—

Ms. Jacky — **the** most serious English teacher in my school— always assigned us difficult tasks or homework; sometimes even she herself **didn’t** know the correct answer. Although she only assigns homework once every three months, it means we have to slip into the **hardest** hell four times a year!

While I was trying to **take out** my English dictionary and **solve** the questions step by step, a paper flitted over from my shelf; **it was** an exquisite envelope from a friend at school— Sandy.

Sandy, the most unique friend among my **besties**, always sends letters instead of sending **e-mails**. Out of curiosity, I removed the tape that **stuck** on the envelope softly, and took out the **letter** inside as **carefully** as I could:

“The homework **that was** assigned by Ms. Jacky this week is the most difficult project that I have **ever** encountered **before!** I plan to discuss this problem with Ms. Jacky tomorrow, and **clearly** express the **hurdles** we **face**, and why we are unable to complete the assignment..... But I understand that I don’t have enough courage to talk to the most serious teacher at school; I hope you **can** solve this problem with me!”

After I finished reading the last line **of** small **print** in the letter, a strange feeling welled up in my mind. **It was** a mixture of self-blame and admiration. I noticed that I was too timid; I **had** also once wanted to discuss **these** difficulties with Ms. Jacky before, **but was** disheartened because **of** a lack of courage — **a** quarter of **an** hour was filled with peace and silence.

After some hesitation, our hellish homework **was** replaced by the teacher’s **praise**:

“I never intended to become a burden to you.” Ms. Jacky’s eyes showed a hint of surprise. “I just want to lay the foundation for your future, all of you! I apologize for my lack of awareness!” She said gently and **patted** our heads softly. “Thank you for telling me this.” Her last sentence attracted my attention. “You are the bravest **students** I have ever seen.”

IMPROVED VERSION

This version rewrites the essay for clarity, flow, and natural expression while preserving the original voice and meaning.

On a quiet Sunday morning, golden sunlight filtered through the curtains and filled my room with warmth. “What a peaceful moment,” I murmured, stretching lazily — but today, there was no smile on my face. The massive project assigned by Ms. Jacky had swallowed my entire weekend whole.

Ms. Jacky was, without question, the strictest English teacher in our school. She had a reputation for handing out assignments so difficult that even she herself sometimes struggled with the answers. She only assigned homework once every three months, but each time felt like marching straight into battle — and we had to survive it four times a year.

I dragged myself to my desk and reached for my English dictionary, determined to tackle the questions one by one. Just then, a piece of paper fluttered down from the shelf above me. I picked it up — it was an exquisite envelope, decorated with tiny flowers. The sender was Sandy, a friend from school.

Sandy was unlike anyone else I knew. In an age of instant messages and social media, she still preferred to communicate through handwritten letters. Filled with curiosity, I gently peeled the tape off the envelope and carefully unfolded the letter inside:

“The homework Ms. Jacky assigned this week is the hardest thing I have ever encountered! I want to talk to her tomorrow and explain the obstacles we are facing and why finishing this assignment feels impossible... But the truth is, I don’t have the courage to confront the strictest teacher in school by myself. Will you face this challenge with me?”

I read the last line of her small, neat handwriting, and a strange wave of emotion washed over me — a tangled mixture of guilt and admiration. Guilt, because I realized I was just as timid as Sandy. I, too, had once thought about raising these concerns with Ms. Jacky, but each time, fear held me back. And admiration, because Sandy had found the courage to at least reach out and ask for help. I set the letter down and sat in silence for what felt like an eternity, turning her words over in my mind.

Eventually, we made our decision. Hearts pounding, we walked up to Ms. Jacky together after class. To our surprise, she did not scold us. Instead, her expression softened.

“I never intended to become a burden to you,” she said quietly, her eyes wide. “All I want is to lay a strong foundation for your future. I am sorry — I should have been more aware of how you were feeling.” She reached out and gently patted our heads. “Thank you for telling me this.” Then she paused, and her final words caught me completely off guard: “You are the bravest students I have ever seen.”

PART A: VOCABULARY (12 Words)

Study the following vocabulary words from the improved text. Pay attention to how each word is used in context.

#	Word	Definition & Example from Text
1	filter (v.)	to pass through something gradually. "Golden sunlight filtered through the curtains."
2	massive (adj.)	very large or serious in scale. "The massive project assigned by Ms. Jacky had swallowed my entire weekend."
3	reputation (n.)	the opinion that people have about someone based on past behavior. "She had a reputation for handing out assignments so difficult..."
4	tackle (v.)	to make an effort to deal with a difficult problem. "Determined to tackle the questions one by one."
5	flutter (v.)	to move lightly and quickly through the air. "A piece of paper fluttered down from the shelf above me."
6	exquisite (adj.)	extremely beautiful and delicate. "It was an exquisite envelope, decorated with tiny flowers."
7	obstacle (n.)	something that blocks your way or makes progress difficult. "Explain the obstacles we are facing."
8	confront (v.)	to face a difficult situation or person directly. "I don't have the courage to confront the strictest teacher in school."
9	timid (adj.)	shy and lacking courage. "I realized I was just as timid as Sandy."
10	admiration (n.)	a feeling of respect and approval. "A tangled mixture of guilt and admiration."
11	eternity (n.)	an extremely long period of time. "I sat in silence for what felt like an eternity."
12	scold (v.)	to speak angrily to someone for doing something wrong. "To our surprise, she did not scold us."

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. The morning light _____ through the window and warmed the room.
 - a) fluttered
 - b) filtered
 - c) tackled
 - d) scolded

2. She has a _____ for being the toughest professor in the department.
 - a) obstacle
 - b) admiration
 - c) reputation
 - d) eternity

3. He was too _____ to raise his hand in class, even when he knew the answer.
 - a) massive
 - b) exquisite
 - c) distinctive
 - d) timid

4. The leaves _____ to the ground as the autumn wind blew.
 - a) filtered
 - b) confronted
 - c) fluttered
 - d) tackled

5. The team decided to _____ the hardest problem first.
 - a) scold
 - b) tackle
 - c) flutter
 - d) filter

6. The teacher _____ the student for not finishing the homework on time.
 - a) admired
 - b) confronted

- c) filtered
- d) scolded

7. Waiting in the hospital felt like an _____ before the doctor finally came.

- a) obstacle
- b) eternity
- c) admiration
- d) reputation

8. She felt deep _____ for her grandmother, who had raised five children on her own.

- a) admiration
- b) eternity
- c) obstacle
- d) reputation

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

Complete each sentence with the correct word from the box.

massive — exquisite — confront — obstacle — filter — timid — flutter — tackle

1. The butterflies began to _____ around the garden in the spring breeze.
2. Language barriers can be a major _____ when traveling in a foreign country.
3. The cake was decorated with _____ detail — every flower looked real.
4. She knew she had to _____ her fear of public speaking sooner or later.
5. Soft music seemed to _____ through the walls from the café next door.
6. The company faces a _____ challenge in rebuilding customer trust.
7. As a child, he was quite _____, but he gradually became more confident.
8. The best way to _____ a difficult project is to break it into smaller steps.

PART B: GRAMMAR PATTERNS

1. “In an age of + noun, S + V”

Use this pattern to set a contrasting context — what is common now vs. what someone does differently.

Example from text: *“In an age of instant messages and social media, she still preferred to communicate through handwritten letters.”*

More examples:

- In an age of fast food, he still cooks every meal from scratch.
- In an age of streaming services, she still visits the local library every week.

2. “Hearts pounding, S + V” (Absolute Phrase)

An absolute phrase uses a noun + participle to describe a physical or emotional state that accompanies the main action.

Example from text: *“Hearts pounding, we walked up to Ms. Jacky together after class.”*

More examples:

- Hands shaking, she opened the envelope containing her exam results.
- Voice trembling, he stood up and delivered his speech.

3. “All + S + V + is/was + to + verb”

Use this pattern to express a sole purpose or intention — emphasizing that someone wants only one thing.

Example from text: *“All I want is to lay a strong foundation for your future.”*

More examples:

- All she wanted was to hear the truth.
- All he needs is to get a good night’s sleep.

4. “Each time, + noun/clause + held someone back”

Use this pattern to describe repeated failed attempts — something that prevented action again and again.

Example from text: *“I, too, had once thought about raising these concerns, but each time, fear held me back.”*

More examples:

- He wanted to apologize, but each time, his pride held him back.
- She planned to quit her job, but each time, financial worry held her back.

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best answer to complete each sentence.

1. _____ of online shopping, she still prefers to visit stores in person.
 - a) At an age
 - b) In an age
 - c) On an age
 - d) For an age

2. _____, the children stepped onto the stage for their first performance.
 - a) Hearts pound
 - b) Heart pounding
 - c) Hearts pounding
 - d) Hearts were pounding

3. All she wanted _____ to hear the truth.
 - a) is
 - b) was
 - c) were
 - d) been

4. He wanted to apologize, but each time, his pride _____ him back.
 - a) holds
 - b) holding
 - c) held
 - d) was hold

5. In an age of artificial intelligence, many people _____ about the future of their jobs.
 - a) still worry
 - b) still worried
 - c) worrying still
 - d) still are worry

6. _____, we rushed to the gate just in time.
 - a) Heart pounded
 - b) Hearts pounding

- c) Hearts pound
- d) Our hearts pound

7. All I need _____ a good night's sleep.

- a) are
- b) were
- c) is
- d) been

8. She tried to speak up, but each time, self-doubt _____ her back.

- a) hold
- b) holding
- c) was hold
- d) held

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite each sentence using the given pattern.

In an age of + noun, S + V

1. People use GPS everywhere now, but my grandfather still reads paper maps.

2. Most people stream music online, but she still collects vinyl records.

Hearts pounding, S + V (Absolute Phrase)

3. The students were very nervous. They opened the exam results.

4. We were extremely anxious. We knocked on the principal's door.

All + S + V + is/was + to + verb

5. The only thing she wanted was to pass the exam.

6. The only thing he needs is to get some rest.

Each time, + noun/clause + held someone back

7. He planned to ask for a raise many times, but his fear always stopped him.

8. She wanted to travel alone, but her parents' worry always stopped her.

ANSWER KEY

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b) filtered 2. c) reputation 3. d) timid 4. c) fluttered 5. b) tackle 6. d) scolded 7. b) eternity
8. a) admiration

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

1. flutter 2. obstacle 3. exquisite 4. confront 5. filter 6. massive 7. timid 8. tackle

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b) In an age 2. c) Hearts pounding 3. b) was 4. c) held 5. a) still worry 6. b) Hearts
pounding 7. c) is 8. d) held

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation (Sample Answers)

1. In an age of GPS, my grandfather still reads paper maps.
2. In an age of music streaming, she still collects vinyl records.
3. Hearts pounding, the students opened the exam results.
4. Hearts pounding, we knocked on the principal's door.
5. All she wanted was to pass the exam.
6. All he needs is to get some rest.
7. He planned to ask for a raise many times, but each time, fear held him back.
8. She wanted to travel alone, but each time, her parents' worry held her back.